

Other Preparations

Different herbal preparations suit different ailments. Most of the following preparations provide localized relief. Steam inhalations, for example, help clear various respiratory complaints; gargles and mouthwashes soothe sore throats and mouth ulcers; massage oils can ease aching muscles; and skin washes relieve inflamed skin conditions.

Steam Inhalations

Steam inhalations are an effective way to clear congestion and relieve sinusitis, hay fever, and bronchial asthma. The combination of steam and antiseptic ingredients clears the airways throughout the respiratory system.

To make Pour 1 quart of freshly boiled water into a large bowl, add 5–10 drops of essential oil, and stir well. Alternatively, make an infusion of 25 g of herb to 1 quart of water, brew for 15 minutes, and pour into a bowl. Cover the head and bowl with a towel, close the eyes, and inhale the steam for about 10 minutes or until the preparation cools. After a steam inhalation, it is advisable to stay in a warm room for 15 minutes to allow the airways to adjust and any congestion to clear.

Inhalations
using essential
oil relieve many
respiratory complaints.



Gargles & Mouthwashes

Gargles and mouthwashes usually contain astringent herbs, which tighten the mucous membranes of the mouth and throat. Astringent herbs such as rhatany (*Krameria triandra*, p. 225) and myrrh (*Commiphora molmol*, p. 85), can be made more palatable and more effective for sore throats by adding a little licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101) or a pinch of cayenne pepper (*Capsicum frutescens*, p. 74) to the preparation. As gargles and mouthwashes are made from infusions, decoctions, or diluted tinctures, they can generally be swallowed for internal treatment. Ensure you do not exceed the daily internal dose of an herb.

To make Make an infusion (see p. 291) but allow it to stand for 15–20 minutes in order to increase its

Infusions made with
antiseptic herbs make
useful gargles and
mouthwashes for sore
throats and mouth ulcers.



astringency. Strain, then gargle, or rinse the mouth with a cupful. Alternatively, use a decoction (p. 291) or dilute about 1 tsp (5 ml) of tincture in ½ cup (100 ml) of hot water and use in the same way. Repeat as often as required unless specified.

Pessaries & Suppositories

Pessaries and suppositories are waxy pellets containing essential oil or fine powder. They are used when oral medicine is likely to be broken down during digestion before reaching its intended site. Pessaries are inserted into the vagina and suppositories into the anus, where they melt at body temperature. The herb is quickly absorbed into the bloodstream, providing fast relief. It is best to buy ready-made suppositories.

To make pessaries Use a pessary mold or make 24 molds from cooking foil shaped around a thimble. Mix 10 g of soft soap, 2 tbsp plus 2 tsp (50 ml) of glycerine and 2 tbsp (40 ml) of methylated spirits and pour into the molds. Leave for a few minutes to coat the molds, then pour out the excess and leave to harden. Melt 20 g of cocoa butter, remove from the heat, and add 30 drops of essential oil or 5 g of powder. Pour into the shells and leave to set for 3 hours, before removing the pessaries. Store in a cool place in a pot lined with greaseproof paper for up to 3 months.

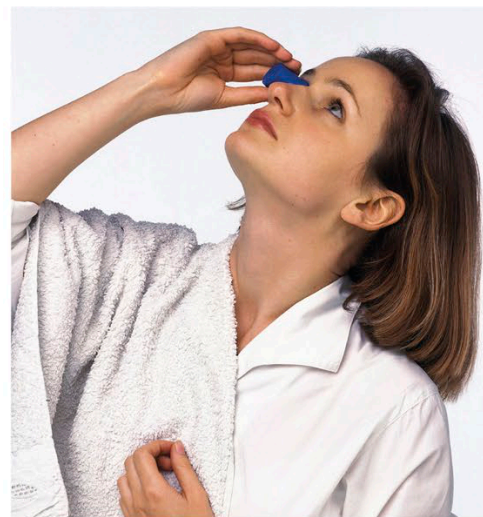
Essential Oils

Essential oils can be used in massage to soothe minor aches and pains. Before use, they should be diluted with a carrier oil as they can irritate the skin. Essential oils deteriorate rapidly after dilution, so it is best to mix small quantities as you need them.

For massage Mix 5–10 drops of essential oil with 1 tbsp of carrier oil, such as wheatgerm or almond oil, and massage gently into the skin.

Oil burner Use 5–10 drops of neat essential oil mixed with water. Burn for 30 minutes.

Essential oils are
used in baths and
oil burners, and in
massage to relieve
tension and stress.



The eyebath is applied to the affected eye and the head is tilted well back.

Baths & Skin Washes

Herbal baths and skin washes can relieve many conditions, including aching limbs and stuffy sinuses. They are made from diluted essential oils or infusions. Eyebaths soothe sore, inflamed, or irritated eyes.

To make an herbal bath Add 2 cups (500 ml) of strained infusion (see p. 291) or 5–10 drops of essential oil to a running bath.

To make a skin wash Make an infusion, strain it, and bathe the affected area.

To make an eyebath Make a small quantity of an infusion or use an herbal teabag. Strain the liquid carefully into a sterilized eyebath. Alternatively, add 2–3 drops of a tincture to an eyebath filled with water that has just boiled. Allow to cool and place the eyebath firmly over the eye. Tip the head back and bathe the eye by continuously blinking. Repeat up to 3 times a day.

General cautions Eyebaths should be very weak, so as not to sting the eyes. Always use boiled, cooled water in a sterilized container. Do not bathe eyes over a period of more than 2–3 weeks at a time. If bathing eyes frequently, add a tiny pinch of salt to each eyebath to counter leaching of salts and minerals from the eye.

Cold Macerations

Heat destroys the active constituents of some herbs, and a cold maceration is more appropriate than a decoction.

To make Pour 2 cups (500 ml) of cold water over 25 g of herb and leave to stand overnight. Strain and use as you would a decoction

Juices

The juices extracted from many herbs can be taken internally or applied externally.

To make Pulp the plant, preferably using a mechanical juicer. Otherwise use a food processor. Squeeze the pulp through a jelly bag to collect the juice. Some herbs need to be cooked in order to extract their juice.